Sherif Abaza

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GLOBAL HEAD OF EVENTS · OPENAI · SAN FRANCISCO

Dear OpenAI hiring team,

I'm applying for Global Head of Events. For twenty years I have run events as a business: setting the strategy, deciding where the investment goes, building the teams and agency relationships that deliver it, and answering for the results.

I founded Sphere Events in Dubai and led it for ten years, growing it into a 140-person company with more than USD 8 million in annual revenue and clients including Siemens, Porsche, Cartier, Ericsson and Emaar. I created the company's own event properties, Street Nights, Marina Music Festival and the Dubai Chocolate Festival, and built each into a recurring franchise with its own sponsors, partners and audience. Running that company meant making portfolio decisions every year: which formats to grow, where to invest, and how to price the work so we could keep raising the standard.

I then spent eight years on the executive team at Withlocals, first as Chief Growth Officer and then as Chief Community Officer. I set the growth strategy and market priorities that took the company from 50 to more than 300 cities, created its B2B partnership business, and led a community of more than 2,000 partners. When travel stopped during the pandemic, I led the company's move into virtual experiences, which won more than 70 corporate clients in under 90 days with no paid marketing. Taking an established organisation through a sharp change of direction is something I would bring to a large events team that is being asked to define what comes next.

Through my own consultancy I advise global brands, including Barry Callebaut, on event portfolio strategy and investment, and I led delivery for COP27, COP28 and COP29. I have also been the strategic delivery partner for agencies such as Jack Morton, Shelton Fleming and Impact XM, so I know how to build an agency model that gets their best work. Putting heads of state, executives, scientists and media into the same programme has shaped how I think about audiences: each group arrives with a different question, and a good event answers all of them inside one coherent story. OpenAI's audiences of developers, business leaders, customers, partners and communities need the same thinking.

AI is part of how I work every day. I'm not a developer, yet I have designed and shipped two products through AI coding agents, and I use AI across event planning, from portfolio and budget analysis to briefs and attendee communications. I'd want OpenAI's events team to be the clearest example of what a creative organisation can do with these tools.

I would judge the portfolio by what people can do once they leave: developers building, customers adopting, partners committing. I'm based in the Netherlands, ready to relocate to San Francisco, and would welcome a conversation about where OpenAI's events go next.

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